

Chapter 16

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- An explanation of *moral panic* and *moral entrepreneur/crusader*
- The ten stages of a moral panic
- The Oakland Ebonics Controversy of 1996-1997, in which the Oakland, CA School Board proposed to use AAVE in the classroom in order to teach AAVE-speaking children *SAE
- The ten stages of the moral panic over the Oakland Ebonics Controversy of 1996-1997

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

1. *Perhaps the best popular illustration of how a moral panic originates is found in The Music Man, a musical comedy that first appeared on stage and later, on film. A con man comes to small town Iowa; his first step is to engage the trust of the community. He consults an old friend as he's considering his approach. Clips of this small segment can be found on YouTube (search "The Music Man" and "Ya Got Trouble" together). This is in fact a comedy, but it does a good job of demonstrating the whole process in a short time. Have a look at it and decide who Harold Hill is: moral entrepreneur or devil?*

Sample answer: I think Harold Hill is a posing as a moral entrepreneur—he starts the moral panic, but he doesn't actually think that there is a real threat to societal values or interests. He just wants to make the town think there is so he can offer a moral alternative to the vices of the pool hall—for a fee, of course. This makes me wonder about who profits in moral panics. I suppose that even when there is no clear beneficiary, the media would benefit because people would be watching, listening, and searching online in order to find out more information about an issue that concerns them, which means profits for the media.

2. *This question was posed in the chapter: If African Americans are indeed Americans, why would they want to claim allegiance to a language other than American English? Here is a hypothetical response. Does it compare? How, or how not?*

What do you mean, you want to go home? So you own a home of your own, but we went to such trouble to make a comfortable spot for you in the servants' quarters.

Sample answer: I think this answers compares in some ways. Asking someone to give up AAVE in exchange for *SAE in a society in which institutionalized racism against African Americans is so firmly established is in some ways like asking someone to give up their own comfortable, familiar home for the servants' quarters in an unfriendly house. However, this hypothetical answer doesn't account for the fact that AAVE is one of many realizations of American English, so maybe *SAE and AAVE would be two different wings on the same house. In addition, when I think of servants' quarters I think of smaller, shabbier living quarters than the

main house. But, since both *SAE and AAVE are equally systematic and expressive, an AAVE-speaker's *SAE would not actually be any less valuable than a non-AAVE speaker's *SAE (regardless of what society might think).

3. *Select two or three clips provided in the case study and do a close reading and analysis. How do they (or don't they) fit into the language subordination model?*

Sample answer: I chose to analyze the following clips provided in this chapter:

School Board 24 in western Queens last week became the first in the city to officially ban Ebonics, or so-called black English, from its classrooms. Board members voted unanimously Thursday night to "reject any recognition of Ebonics as a distinct and legitimate language" and compared it to "unacceptable grammar" and a "decimation of the English language." Daily News, 1/27/1997

Last spring the Cornell Review, a conservative student publication, published a parody--a description, in ebonics, of courses that might be taught in Cornell's Africana Studies and Resource Center. An excerpt from a prospective course, Racism in American Society "Da white man be evil an he tryin to keep da brotherman down. We s got Sharpton an Farakhan, so who da white man now, white boy?...We aint gots to axe da white man for nothin in dis class". Obviously the parody was intended to offend and insult. And indeed, I would call it racist, as did many black students at Cornell. The authors of the parody deny it was intended to be racist. But Rosa Clemente, a first-year graduate student, spoke for many of the angry targets of the parody: I m tired of asking for my humanity. Village Voice, 9/30/1997

The Ku Klux Klan could not have come up with a better plan to impede the academic progress of young black children than the idea of teaching Ebonics as a separate language. Crain's Chicago Business 1/27/1997

These clips illustrate several points in the language subordination model. For example, AAVE is trivialized and mocked as not just an illegitimate language variety but an ungrammatical perversion of English. In addition, the third clip suggests that using AAVE in the classroom will have such horrible repercussions for African American students that the program could have been designed by the Ku Klux Klan. The unstated flip side to this is that assimilating to *SAE will have economic rewards for the students in the future, both of which are major parts of the language subordination process.

4. *In his article about his own involvement in the Oakland controversy, John Rickford talks a little about how linguists experienced personal fallout from the public:*

One thing that I naively did not expect was the subtle and not-so-subtle nastiness that issues of language can elicit from the public. I encountered this in the occasionally severe distortions of information which I had shared with reporters in good faith, and in the "hate mail" which my quoted remarks in the press elicited. One example of distortive reporting

was Jacob Heilbrunn's Ebonics article in the January 20, 1997 issue of The New Republic, to which I responded with a letter in the March 3, 1997 issue. One example of the hate mail was a postcard I received addressed to "John Rickford, Linguistics Professor (God Help Us All)" which included, alongside a newspaper report of my remarks at the 1997 LSA meeting, the comment: "It's just amazing how much crap you so-called 'scholars' can pour and get away with. Can you wonder, John Boy, why the general public does not trust either educators, judges or politicians? As a brother might say, 'Ee Bonic be a bunch a booshit man, but it get de muny offa de White man. He be a sucka.'" "Geoff Pullum also got hate mail for his Nature piece, as did Rosina Lippi-Green for her New York Times letter to the editor in December 1996. It comes with the territory (Rickford 1999c).

Below is the letter mentioned in Rickford's article, which I wrote to The New York Times after they published an editorial on the Oakland controversy. Following that are partial transcripts of two of the many letters I received through the mail. Questions for discussion follow.

December 26, 1996

To the Editor:

In your Dec. 24 editorial "Linguistic Confusion" you demonstrate considerable confusion of your own.

The body of research on the history of that variety of American English called Black English or African American Vernacular English is anything but "dubious." Because the school board in Oakland, Calif., prefers the term "ebonics" does not change the well-documented body of empirical, quantitative socio-linguistics that underlies what we know about the history and structure of that language. A more thorough examination of the topic would have provided you with input from linguists who could make the facts available to you.

This is yet another example of the media's biased reporting on language issues, in its self-appointed role as arbiter of a spoken "standard" language -- a mythical beast you will never define with any clarity because it does not exist.

Discrimination on the basis of language variation linked to race, national origin and economics exists not because the language is worthless or less than functional, but because newspapers and other voices of authority insist that such discrimination is right and because we have been pushing that message for so long that most people no longer think to examine the false logic and spurious common-sense arguments.

You and other papers have printed strong criticism of the Oakland board's action by prominent and intellectual African-Americans, but you have not sought out those who would speak rationally to the other side of this issue. There are interviews with Maya Angelou but none with the Nobel Prize winner Toni Morrison. The Rev. Jesse Jackson has drowned

out James Baldwin's famous 1979 editorial 'If Black English Isn't a Language, Then Tell Me, What Is?'

If you cannot look to your own archives, go to the major research universities in this country where African-American and other linguists have produced a significant body of work that might have given you some facts to work with. I suggest you start with the linguists John Rickford, John Baugh and Geneva Smitherman.

ROSINA LIPPI-GREEN Ann Arbor, Mich., Dec. 24, 1996

The writer is an associate professor of linguistics, University of Michigan.

Responses sent through the mail to me, excerpted:

You should be ashamed of yourself. You know better. You SHOULD know better. Did you get where you are today talking Black?

I agree with you that we need to be more open minded about language. What I wish is that Pig Latin would be accepted. It fits right in there with Ebonics.

What assumptions are the letter writers working with? Why might they have come to such conclusions? What are the primary emotions that come across?

Sample answer: These letter writers are working with the assumption that AAVE is not a legitimate dialect but is a kind of “bad English” on par with the language game Pig Latin (which, to my knowledge, is not acquired as a first language by anybody). For these letter writers, speakers of AAVE cannot succeed in society because AAVE is a deficient way of speaking and should not be accepted. I think the letter writers came to these conclusions as a result of the language subordination process. I think the emotions in these letters—contempt, anger, and sarcasm—are also a result of the language subordination process at work on the people who wrote them. In the introduction, the author of English with an Accent states very clearly that she is of European descent and speaks English with a midwestern accent. Why does the first letter assume the author is an AAVE speaker?

From the website

Audio

1. Listen to the samples of African American English from several areas of the United States. What do you think about these varieties of AAVE being used in the classroom? Explain why you feel the way you do.

Sample answer: I think it would be good to have teachers and students who speak these varieties of AAVE (and others) use AAVE in the classroom in order to recognize the systematicity and expressiveness of AAVE not as “broken English” but as a fully formed dialect of English. If AAVE was valued in schools as a fully functional language, AAVE-speaking students would potentially be more open to adding *SAE into their linguistic repertoires and also be more

receptive to school in general. If nothing else, using AAVE in the classroom would probably give AAVE-speaking students more confidence since their dialect would be validated as a legitimate language variety. Using AAVE as a regular part of classroom activities would also benefit non-AAVE speaking children by teaching them that AAVE is a totally valid language variety that deserves respect.

Video

1. Based on the information in this video clip, compare and contrast the program in San Bernadino County, CA with the program proposed by the Oakland School Board in 1996 that sparked the Oakland Ebonics Controversy. What are the similarities and differences in the programs? What are the similarities and differences in the arguments for and against the use of AAVE in schools that cropped up as a result of these programs?

Sample answer: The two programs are similar because both programs were implemented with the goal of helping AAVE-speaking children succeed in school and both programs were met with skepticism from some. However, the major difference is that the program in San Bernadino County was actually implemented, and, according to the guest arguing for the program, standardized test scores for African American students have improved, so the more recent program has at least some positive results.

The discussion of the use of AAVE in schools in 2011 is very similar to the discussion of this same topic in 1996-1997. The advocate for using AAVE in schools argues that AAVE is a separate language from English (equivalent to a foreign language) and that using AAVE in the classroom is important in order to keep African American students involved in school and help them succeed. The 2011 argument against the use of AAVE in school is also similar to the detractors' argument in the 1990s: both arguments focus on how using AAVE in schools will hurt the futures of African American students to the point that such a program is considered racist against African Americans. Both arguments also focus on the stigmatization of AAVE rather than questioning the institutionalized racism that devalues AAVE.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Ask the students to review all the arguments for and against Oakland School Board's proposal. Which do they find most compelling and why? What do they think about the use of AAVE in classrooms? Have their opinions changed at all after reading this chapter?
2. Ask the students to reflect on the role of the educational system in the language subordination process. What (if anything) can or should be done to minimize the problem of linguistic discrimination?
3. Ask the students to design an interview study in order to find out what people in your area think about using AAVE in classrooms. Discuss the design of the study as a class and have students share their findings with a class.

4. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.